Himaayah Schools
MADRASAH

FREE GUIDE

عَلَيْكُمْ بِسُنَّتِي وَسُنَّةِ الْخُلَفَاءِ الرَّاشِدِينَ الْمَهْدِيِّينَ

"Hold to my Sunnah and the Sunnah of the rightly guided caliphs." (Abū Dāwūd 4607, at-Tirmidhī 2676)

The Four Rightly Guided Caliphs

The lives and caliphates of Abū Bakr, ʿUmar, ʿUthmān and ʿAlī: who they were, how they ruled, and what they left the Ummah.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Before you begin

When the Messenger of Allah ﷺ died in the year 11 after the Hijrah, the Muslims faced the hardest question in their history: who would lead them now? For the next thirty years, four of his closest Companions led the Ummah one after another: **Abū Bakr aṣ-Ṣiddīq, ʿUmar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb, ʿUthmān ibn ʿAffān and ʿAlī ibn Abī Ṭālib** (raḍiyallāhu ʿanhum). Muslims call them **al-Khulafāʾ ar-Rāshidūn**, the rightly guided caliphs.

Under them the Qur'an was gathered into one book and then into one standard muṣḥaf, the Sunnah was preserved and practised, justice was established, and Islām spread from Arabia to Persia, Syria, Egypt and North Africa. They also faced great trials, and three of the four were martyred. This book tells their stories: who they were before Islām, how they accepted it, what they did beside the Prophet ﷺ, how they led the Ummah, and how they died.

فَعَلَيْكُمْ بِسُنَّتِي وَسُنَّةِ الْخُلَفَاءِ الرَّاشِدِينَ الْمَهْدِيِّينَ، عَضُّوا عَلَيْهَا بِالنَّوَاجِذِ

"Hold to my Sunnah and the Sunnah of the rightly guided caliphs. Bite onto it with your molar teeth."

Narrated by Abū Dāwūd (4607) and at-Tirmidhī (2676), who said: ḥasan ṣaḥīḥ.

A note on sources and on the trials

The main events of the caliphs' lives are recorded in Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī and Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim, and in the histories of Ibn Saʿd (aṭ-Ṭabaqāt), aṭ-Ṭabarī (Tārīkh), Ibn Kathīr (al-Bidāyah wan-Nihāyah) and as-Suyūṭī (Tārīkh al-Khulafāʾ). Where a ḥadīth is in the authentic collections, its source is given. Where a story is well known from the histories but its exact details are less certain, this book says "it is reported".

The later years brought painful trials (fitnah) among the Companions. This book explains them as the scholars of Ahl as-Sunnah do: with love for all the Companions, without taking sides against any of them, and with the verse: "Our Lord, forgive us and our brothers who preceded us in faith" (al-Ḥashr 59:10).

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How to read this book

1 Read **one caliph at a time**. Each chapter opens with an at-a-glance table, then tells his life in order: before Islām, with the Prophet ﷺ, as caliph, and his death.

2 Learn **one ḥadīth about each caliph by heart**. Each chapter has several, with their sources.

3 Use the **timeline, the comparison table and the self-test** at the end to fix what you have read.

4 **Teachers and parents:** each chapter can be read in two or three sittings, with the “Lessons for us” as the discussion.

Part 1 The rightly guided caliphate

Khalīfah and rāshidūn

A **khalīfah** is a successor: someone who comes after another and takes his place. The caliphs were not prophets, and revelation ended with the death of the Prophet ﷺ. They succeeded him in leading the Muslims: leading the prayer, judging between people, protecting the religion and caring for the community. Each was chosen by consultation and given the **bayʿah** (pledge of allegiance) by the Muslims.

Ar-rāshidūn means "the rightly guided". The Prophet ﷺ himself described his successors in this way, and he told his Ummah to hold to their Sunnah. He also foretold how long their caliphate would last:

> الْخِلَافَةُ فِي أُمَّتِي ثَلَاثُونَ سَنَةً، ثُمَّ مُلْكٌ بَعْدَ ذَلِكَ
>
> **"The caliphate in my Ummah will be thirty years, then there will be kingship after that."**
>
> Narrated by at-Tirmidhī (2226) and Abū Dāwūd (4646) from Safīnah; graded ḥasan. The thirty years were completed by the caliphate of the four and the six months of al-Ḥasan ibn ʿAlī.

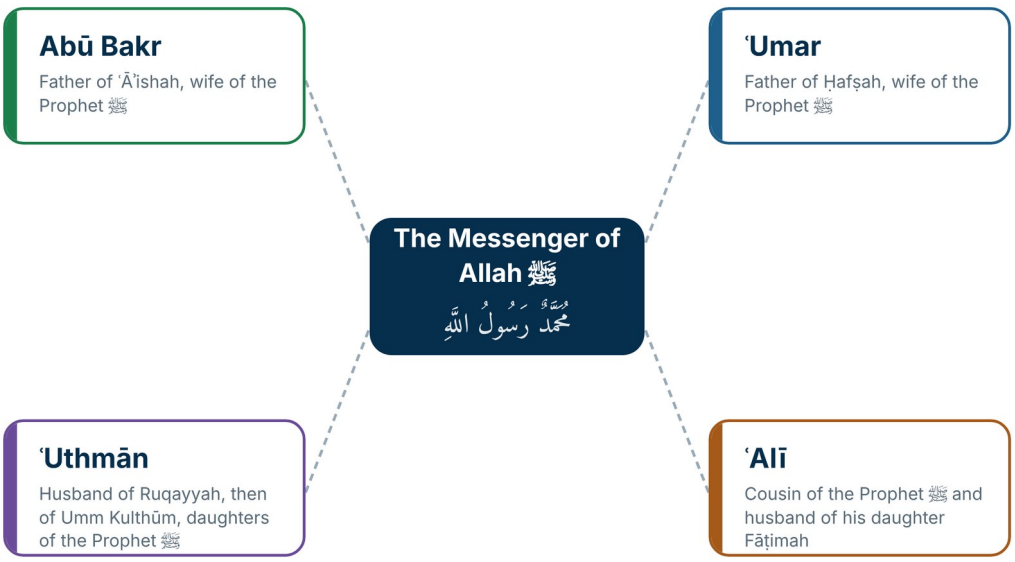
Their order of virtue

All four are among the ten Companions whom the Prophet ﷺ named as people of Paradise in one ḥadīth (at-Tirmidhī, 3747). Ahl as-Sunnah hold that their virtue follows the order of their caliphate: Abū Bakr, then ʿUmar, then ʿUthmān, then ʿAlī. This is based on what the Companions themselves said:

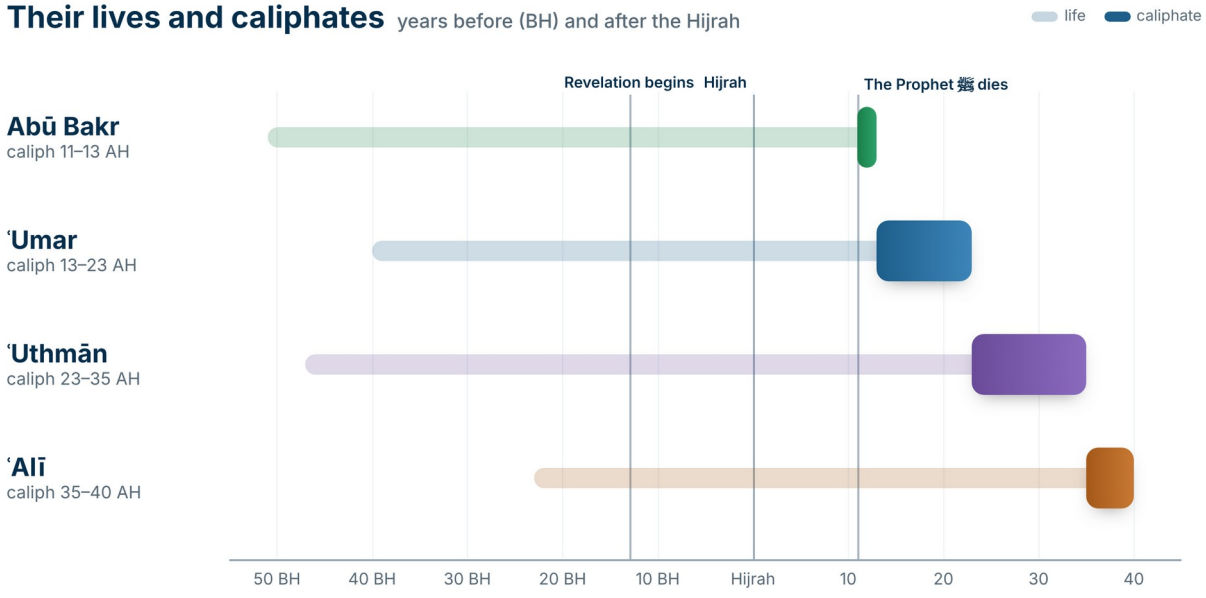
> كُنَّا نُخَيِّرُ بَيْنَ النَّاسِ فِي زَمَنِ النَّبِيِّ ﷺ، فَنُخَيِّرُ أَبَا بَكْرٍ، ثُمَّ عُمَرَ بْنَ الْخَطَّابِ، ثُمَّ عُثْمَانَ بْنَ عَفَّانَ
>
> **"In the time of the Prophet ﷺ we used to compare people, and we would rank Abū Bakr first, then ʿUmar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb, then ʿUthmān ibn ʿAffān."**
>
> ʿAbdullāh ibn ʿUmar, narrated by al-Bukhārī (3655).

And ʿAlī himself, when his son Muḥammad (known as Ibn al-Ḥanafiyyah) asked him who was the best of people after the Messenger of Allah ﷺ, answered: "Abū Bakr." His son asked: "Then who?" He said: "ʿUmar." (al-Bukhārī, 3671).

Bound to the Prophet ﷺ by family



Their lives and caliphates years before (BH) and after the Hijrah



01

THE FOUR CALIPHS · 01

أَبُو بَكْرٍ الصِّدِّيقُ

AṢ-ṢIDDĪQ

Abū Bakr

ʿAbdullāh ibn ʿUthmān (Abū Quḥāfah) at-Taymī

Caliph 11 – 13 AH · 632 – 634 CE · Madinah

1st
free man to accept Islām

2
years and three months as caliph

63
years, the length of his life

Caliph 1 Abū Bakr aṣ-Ṣiddīq: at a glance

Name	ʿAbdullāh ibn ʿUthmān ibn ʿĀmir at-Taymī al-Qurashī. His father ʿUthmān was known as Abū Quḥāfah.
Kunyah and titles	Abū Bakr; **aṣ-Ṣiddīq** (the one who affirms the truth) and **al-ʿAtīq**
Born	In Makkah, about two years after the Year of the Elephant (around 573 CE)
Accepted Islām	The first free adult man to accept Islām
Caliph	From Rabīʿ al-Awwal 11 AH to Jumādā al-Ākhirah 13 AH (632–634 CE), about two years and three months
Died	Jumādā al-Ākhirah 13 AH (634 CE) in Madinah, aged 63; buried beside the Prophet ﷺ
Family	Father of ʿĀʾishah, Mother of the Believers, and of Asmāʾ, “she of the two belts”

Before Islām

Abū Bakr was a successful cloth merchant of the clan of Taym in Quraysh, known for his gentle manners, his knowledge of the genealogies of the Arabs, and his honesty. People came to him for advice and to settle disputes. It is reported that he never drank wine and never worshipped an idol, even before Islām. He was a close friend of Muḥammad ﷺ for years before the revelation.

The first to believe

When the Prophet ﷺ told him of the revelation, Abū Bakr believed at once, without hesitation. He then called others to Islām, and through him came some of the greatest Companions: ʿUthmān ibn ʿAffān, az-Zubayr ibn al-ʿAwwām, ʿAbd ar-Raḥmān ibn ʿAwf, Saʿd ibn Abī Waqqāṣ and Ṭalḥah ibn ʿUbaydillāh. He spent his wealth buying and freeing Muslims who were being tortured by their masters, among them **Bilāl ibn Rabāḥ**.

After the Night Journey (al-Isrāʾ), when the Prophet ﷺ told Quraysh that he had been taken to Jerusalem and back in one night, they rushed to Abū Bakr expecting him to doubt. It is reported that he said: “If he said it, then he has spoken the truth.” From that day he was called **aṣ-Ṣiddīq**.

The companion in the cave

When the Prophet ﷺ was given permission to emigrate, it was Abū Bakr who had the honour of travelling with him. He prepared two camels, and the two hid for three nights in the Cave of Thawr while Quraysh searched for them. When the trackers stood at the mouth of the cave, Abū Bakr said: “O Messenger of Allah, if one of them looked at his feet, he would see us.” The Prophet ﷺ replied:

مَا ظَنُّكَ يَا أَبَا بَكْرٍ بِاثْنَيْنِ اللَّهُ ثَالِثُهُمَا

“What do you think, Abū Bakr, of two whose third is Allah?”

Narrated by al-Bukhārī (3653) and Muslim (2381). Allah mentions this moment in at-Tawbah 9:40: “the second of the two, when they were in the cave”.

Beside the Prophet ﷺ

Abū Bakr was with the Prophet ﷺ at Badr, Uḥud, the Trench and every major event. For the expedition of Tabūk he brought all of his wealth. When the Prophet ﷺ asked him what he had left for his family, he said: “I have left them Allah and His Messenger” (at-Tirmidhī, 3675, ḥasan). ʿAmr ibn al-ʿĀṣ asked the Prophet ﷺ who was the most beloved person to him. He said: “ʿĀ’ishah.” ʿAmr asked: “And among men?” He said: “Her father” (al-Bukhārī 3662, Muslim 2384).

لَوْ كُنْتُ مُتَّخِذًا خَلِيلًا مِنْ أُمَّتِي لَاتَّخَذْتُ أَبَا بَكْرٍ

“If I were to take a close friend (khalīl) from my Ummah, I would take Abū Bakr.”

Narrated by al-Bukhārī (3654) and Muslim (2382).

In his final illness, when he could no longer lead the prayer, the Prophet ﷺ said: “Tell Abū Bakr to lead the people in prayer” (al-Bukhārī 664, Muslim 418), and insisted on it even when others suggested someone else. The Companions understood this as a sign of Abū Bakr’s place.

The day the Prophet ﷺ died

When the Prophet ﷺ died, the Companions were overwhelmed with grief. ʿUmar stood in the mosque saying he had not died. Abū Bakr came, uncovered the Prophet’s ﷺ face, kissed him and said: “You were pure in life and in death.” Then he went out to the people and said:

أَلَا مَنْ كَانَ يَعْبُدُ مُحَمَّدًا ﷺ فَإِنَّ مُحَمَّدًا قَدْ مَاتَ،
وَمَنْ كَانَ يَعْبُدُ اللَّهَ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ حَيٌّ لَا يَمُوتُ

“Whoever worshipped Muḥammad ﷺ, Muḥammad has died. And whoever worships Allah, Allah is Ever-Living and does not die.”

Narrated by al-Bukhārī (3668). He then recited Āl ʿImrān 3:144, and the people felt as if they had never heard the verse before.

The pledge of allegiance

The Anṣār gathered in the hall of Banū Sāʿidah (as-Saqīfah) to discuss who would lead. Abū Bakr, ʿUmar and Abū ʿUbaydah ibn al-Jarrāḥ went to them. After discussion, ʿUmar took Abū Bakr’s hand

and pledged allegiance to him, and the Muhājirūn and Anṣār followed. The next day the people gave him the general pledge in the mosque (al-Bukhārī, 6830). In his first address as caliph he is reported to have said:

> **"I have been put in charge of you, though I am not the best of you. If I do well, help me; and if I do wrong, set me right… Obey me as long as I obey Allah and His Messenger. If I disobey Allah and His Messenger, you owe me no obedience."**
>
> Reported in the sīrah of Ibn Hishām and the histories.

As caliph: firmness in the storm

Abū Bakr's caliphate was short, but it saved the Ummah. Three decisions stand out:

1. **The army of Usāmah.** Before his death the Prophet ﷺ had prepared an army under the young Usāmah ibn Zayd. With Arabia in turmoil, some urged Abū Bakr to keep it in Madinah. He refused to undo what the Prophet ﷺ had decided, and sent it.
2. **The wars of apostasy (ar-riddah).** Some tribes left Islām, false prophets such as Musaylimah appeared, and others refused to pay zakāh. ʿUmar at first hesitated to fight those who still said "lā ilāha illā Allāh". Abū Bakr said: "By Allah, I will fight whoever separates prayer from zakāh" (al-Bukhārī 1400, Muslim 20). ʿUmar later said Allah had opened his heart to see that Abū Bakr was right. At the battle of al-Yamāmah (12 AH), Khālid ibn al-Walīd defeated Musaylimah.
3. **Gathering the Qur'an.** Many ḥuffāẓ were martyred at al-Yamāmah. ʿUmar urged Abū Bakr to gather the Qur'an into one book, and Abū Bakr charged **Zayd ibn Thābit** with it. Zayd said: "By Allah, if they had asked me to move a mountain, it would not have been heavier for me." He gathered it from what was written and what was memorised, and the sheets were kept with Abū Bakr, then ʿUmar, then Ḥafṣah (al-Bukhārī, 4986).

By the end of his caliphate, Arabia was united again and Muslim armies had begun to move into Iraq and Syria; the battle of Ajnādayn was fought in 13 AH.

His death

Abū Bakr fell ill with a fever in Jumādā al-Ākhirah 13 AH. After consulting senior Companions, he appointed ʿUmar to succeed him. When ʿĀ'ishah suggested a new shroud, he asked to be shrouded in his old garments, saying: "The living have more right to new clothes than the dead" (al-Bukhārī, 1387). He died aged 63, the same age as the Prophet ﷺ, and was buried beside him in ʿĀ'ishah's room.

Lessons for us

1	**Believe and stand by the truth**, even when others mock it. That is what made him aṣ-Ṣiddīq.
2	**Spend for Allah.** He freed the oppressed and gave everything he had for Tabūk.
3	**Keep a clear head in a crisis.** On the day of the Prophet's ﷺ death and in the riddah, his firmness held the Ummah together.
4	**A leader asks to be corrected.** "If I do wrong, set me right."
5	**Protect the Qur'an.** His decision to gather it is why every Muslim can hold the whole Qur'an in one book.

02

THE FOUR CALIPHS · 02

عُمَرُ بْنُ الْخَطَّابِ رَضِيَ اللَّهُ عَنْهُ

AL-FĀRŪQ

ʿUmar

ʿUmar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb al-ʿAdawī

Caliph 13 – 23 AH · 634 – 644 CE · Madinah

10
years and a half as caliph

1st
to be called Amīr al-Muʾminīn

63
years, the length of his life

Caliph 2 ʿUmar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb: at a glance

Name	ʿUmar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb ibn Nufayl al-ʿAdawī al-Qurashī
Kunyah and titles	Abū Ḥafṣ; **al-Fārūq** (the one who separates truth from falsehood); the first to be called **Amīr al-Muʾminīn**
Born	In Makkah, about thirteen years after the Year of the Elephant (around 584 CE)
Accepted Islām	Around the sixth year of the Prophethood
Caliph	From Jumādā al-Ākhirah 13 AH to Dhul-Ḥijjah 23 AH (634–644 CE), about ten and a half years
Died	Martyred in Dhul-Ḥijjah 23 AH (644 CE) in Madinah, aged 63; buried beside the Prophet ﷺ and Abū Bakr
Family	Father of Ḥafṣah, Mother of the Believers, and of ʿAbdullāh ibn ʿUmar

Before Islām

ʿUmar was tall, strong and feared, one of the few men of Quraysh who could read and write, and an ambassador for his tribe. At first he was among the harshest enemies of the Muslims.

His acceptance of Islām

The Prophet ﷺ made a special duʿāʾ for him:

> اللَّهُمَّ أَعِزَّ الْإِسْلَامَ بِأَحَبِّ هَذَيْنِ الرَّجُلَيْنِ إِلَيْكَ: بِأَبِي جَهْلٍ أَوْ بِعُمَرَ بْنِ الْخَطَّابِ
>
> **“O Allah, strengthen Islām with whichever of these two men is more beloved to You: Abū Jahl or ʿUmar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb.”**
>
> Narrated by at-Tirmidhī (3681), who said: ḥasan ṣaḥīḥ.

It is reported that ʿUmar set out one day to kill the Prophet ﷺ, and was told that his own sister Fāṭimah and her husband had become Muslim. He went to their house in anger, heard them reciting Sūrat Ṭā Hā, and when he read the verses himself his heart changed. He went to the Prophet ﷺ and accepted Islām. ʿAbdullāh ibn Masʿūd said: “We have been strong ever since ʿUmar accepted Islām” (al-Bukhārī, 3684). The Muslims, who had been praying in secret, began to pray openly at the Kaʿbah.

Beside the Prophet ﷺ

ʿUmar was at every battle and every major decision. More than once, the Qur'an was revealed agreeing with his view. He said: "My Lord agreed with me in three things": taking the Station of Ibrāhīm as a place of prayer, the verse of ḥijāb, and a warning to the Prophet's ﷺ wives (al-Bukhārī, 402).

> إِيهًا يَا ابْنَ الْخَطَّابِ، وَالَّذِي نَفْسِي بِيَدِهِ مَا لَقِيَكَ الشَّيْطَانُ سَالِكًا فَجًّا قَطُّ إِلَّا سَلَكَ فَجًّا غَيْرَ فَجِّكَ
>
> **"O son of al-Khaṭṭāb, by the One in whose hand is my soul, Shayṭān never meets you on a road except that he takes a road other than yours."**
>
> Narrated by al-Bukhārī (3683) and Muslim (2396).

The Prophet ﷺ also said that among earlier nations there were people who were inspired (muḥaddathūn), "and if there is one in my Ummah, it is ʿUmar" (al-Bukhārī, 3689). He saw ʿUmar in a dream wearing a long shirt, which he interpreted as the religion (al-Bukhārī, 23).

As caliph: the conquests

Under ʿUmar, the Muslim state grew from Arabia into one of the largest in the world, in about ten years:

- **Syria:** the great victory of al-Yarmūk (15 AH) under Abū ʿUbaydah ibn al-Jarrāḥ and Khālid ibn al-Walīd opened Syria and Palestine.
- **Iraq and Persia:** Saʿd ibn Abī Waqqāṣ defeated the Persians at al-Qādisiyyah (around 15–16 AH) and took their capital, al-Madāʾin. The battle of Nahāwand (21 AH) broke the Persian empire.
- **Jerusalem (16 AH):** the city's leaders asked to surrender to the caliph himself. ʿUmar travelled from Madinah, received the city peacefully, and granted its people security for their lives, churches and property.
- **Egypt:** ʿAmr ibn al-ʿĀṣ opened Egypt (around 20–21 AH) and founded al-Fusṭāṭ.

As caliph: justice and a state

ʿUmar built much of what a state needs, always with consultation (shūrā):

What he established	Details
The Hijrī calendar	Dating years from the Hijrah, adopted around 17 AH on the advice of ʿAlī; still used by Muslims today.
The dīwān	Registers of soldiers and citizens, with regular stipends from the treasury.
Governors held to account	He checked governors' wealth and removed those who were complained about, even great Companions.
Judges	Appointed judges in the provinces, separate from governors, with written guidance on judging.
New cities	Founded al-Kūfah and al-Baṣrah in Iraq and al-Fusṭāṭ in Egypt.
Tarāwīḥ in congregation	Gathered the people behind one reciter, Ubayy ibn Kaʿb, in Ramaḍān (al-Bukhārī, 2010).

He lived simply, ate plain food and wore patched clothes. In the Year of Ashes (ar-Ramādah, 18 AH), when famine struck Arabia, it is reported that he refused meat and butter until the people could eat them too, until his skin darkened. In the same year, plague broke out in Syria. ʿUmar, on his way there, consulted the Companions and turned back. When Abū ʿUbaydah asked: "Are you fleeing from the decree of Allah?" he replied: "Yes, we flee from the decree of Allah to the decree of Allah" (al-Bukhārī, 5729).

> **"If a sheep were to die lost on the banks of the Euphrates, I fear that Allah would ask me about it on the Day of Resurrection."**
>
> Reported from ʿUmar by Abū Nuʿaym in al-Ḥilyah and others.

His martyrdom

In Dhul-Ḥijjah 23 AH, while ʿUmar was leading the Fajr prayer, Abū Luʾluʾah, a Persian slave, stabbed him several times with a dagger. ʿAbd ar-Raḥmān ibn ʿAwf completed the prayer. When ʿUmar learned who had attacked him, he said: "Praise be to Allah who did not make my death at the hands of a man who claims Islām." He sent his son to ask ʿĀʾishah whether he could be buried beside his two companions; she said: "I had wanted it for myself, but I prefer him to myself today." He named six Companions to choose the next caliph by consultation: ʿUthmān, ʿAlī, Ṭalḥah, az-Zubayr, Saʿd ibn Abī Waqqāṣ and ʿAbd ar-Raḥmān ibn ʿAwf (al-Bukhārī, 3700). He died three days later, aged 63.

> **"I always hoped that Allah would place you with your two companions, for I often heard the Prophet ﷺ say: I, Abū Bakr and ʿUmar went… I, Abū Bakr and ʿUmar entered… I, Abū Bakr and ʿUmar came out."**
>
> ʿAlī ibn Abī Ṭālib, standing over ʿUmar's body, narrated by al-Bukhārī (3685).

Lessons for us

1	**People change.** The man who set out to kill the Prophet ﷺ became one of the greatest Muslims. Never give up on anyone.
2	**Strength serves the truth.** ʿUmar's strength, once used against Islām, became its protection.
3	**Leaders are servants and are accountable**, even for a lost sheep.
4	**Consult, and accept the right view.** He changed his mind when shown a better way.
5	**Take means and trust Allah.** Turning back from the plague was "from the decree of Allah to the decree of Allah".

03

THE FOUR CALIPHS · 03

عُثْمَانُ بْنُ عَفَّانَ

DHUN-NŪRAYN

ʿUthmān

ʿUthmān ibn ʿAffān al-Umawī

Caliph 23 – 35 AH · 644 – 656 CE · Madinah

2
daughters of the Prophet ﷺ married to him

12
years as caliph

1
standard muṣḥaf for the whole Ummah

Caliph 3 ʿUthmān ibn ʿAffān: at a glance

Name	ʿUthmān ibn ʿAffān ibn Abī al-ʿĀṣ al-Umawī al-Qurashī, of the clan of Banū Umayyah
Kunyah and title	Abū ʿAbdillāh; **Dhun-Nūrayn**, "the possessor of the two lights", because he married two daughters of the Prophet ﷺ
Born	About six years after the Year of the Elephant (around 576 CE)
Accepted Islām	Early, through Abū Bakr; he emigrated twice, to Abyssinia and to Madinah
Caliph	From Muḥarram 24 AH to Dhul-Ḥijjah 35 AH (644–656 CE), about twelve years
Died	Martyred on 18 Dhul-Ḥijjah 35 AH (656 CE) in his house in Madinah, in his eighties; buried in al-Baqīʿ
Family	Married Ruqayyah, then Umm Kulthūm, daughters of the Prophet ﷺ

Before and after Islām

ʿUthmān was a wealthy and respected merchant, known for his modesty, gentleness and generosity. He accepted Islām early, when Abū Bakr spoke to him, and married **Ruqayyah**, the Prophet's ﷺ daughter. Together they were among the first Muslims to emigrate to Abyssinia to escape persecution, and later emigrated to Madinah.

When the Muslims marched to Badr, Ruqayyah was gravely ill, and the Prophet ﷺ told ʿUthmān to stay and care for her; she died during those days, and the Prophet ﷺ gave ʿUthmān a share and a reward like those who fought (al-Bukhārī, 3130). He then married her sister **Umm Kulthūm**, and so was called Dhun-Nūrayn.

His generosity

In Madinah, the Muslims needed fresh water, and the well of Rūmah belonged to a man who sold its water. The Prophet ﷺ asked who would buy it for the Muslims, promising Paradise, and ʿUthmān bought it and gave it to all (narrated by at-Tirmidhī, 3703, and mentioned by al-Bukhārī). For the expedition of Tabūk, in a year of hardship, he equipped a great part of the army. He brought a thousand dinars and poured them into the Prophet's ﷺ lap, and the Prophet ﷺ said:

> مَا ضَرَّ عُثْمَانَ مَا عَمِلَ بَعْدَ الْيَوْمِ
>
> **"Nothing ʿUthmān does after today will harm him."**
>
> Narrated by at-Tirmidhī (3701), who said: ḥasan.

His modesty

ʿUthmān was famous for ḥayāʾ (modesty). ʿĀʾishah narrated that the Prophet ﷺ was sitting with his garment raised from his leg when Abū Bakr and then ʿUmar entered, and he stayed as he was; when ʿUthmān entered, he sat up and arranged his clothes. When she asked why, he said:

> أَلَا أَسْتَحِي مِنْ رَجُلٍ تَسْتَحِي مِنْهُ الْمَلَائِكَةُ
>
> **"Should I not feel shy before a man before whom the angels feel shy?"**
>
> Narrated by Muslim (2401).

At al-Ḥudaybiyah (6 AH), the Prophet ﷺ sent ʿUthmān to Quraysh as his envoy. When a rumour spread that he had been killed, the Companions gave the Pledge of Riḍwān under the tree. The Prophet ﷺ raised his right hand and said: "This is the hand of ʿUthmān," and struck it on his other hand, pledging on his behalf (al-Bukhārī, 3698).

How he became caliph

The six Companions named by ʿUmar met to choose. ʿAbd ar-Raḥmān ibn ʿAwf withdrew his own name and spent three days consulting the leading Companions, the commanders and the people of Madinah, then gave the pledge to ʿUthmān, and ʿAlī and everyone else pledged after him (al-Bukhārī, 7207).

As caliph

- **The conquests continued**: North Africa (Ifrīqiyah, around 27 AH), Armenia, Khurāsān and beyond.
- **The first Muslim navy**: in around 28 AH, Muʿāwiyah led the first sea expedition to Cyprus. The Prophet ﷺ had foretold that some of his Ummah would ride the sea "like kings on thrones", and Umm Ḥarām bint Milḥān, who asked to be among them, took part and died on that expedition (al-Bukhārī, 2788–2789).
- **The Prophet's Mosque** in Madinah was expanded and rebuilt in stone.

The standard muṣḥaf

ʿUthmān's greatest service was to the Qur'an. The Companion **Ḥudhayfah ibn al-Yamān**, returning from a campaign in Armenia and Azerbaijan, was alarmed at how Muslims from different regions argued over their ways of reciting. He said to ʿUthmān: "Save this Ummah before they differ over the Book as the Jews and Christians differed." ʿUthmān asked Ḥafṣah for the sheets gathered under Abū Bakr. He appointed **Zayd ibn Thābit, ʿAbdullāh ibn az-Zubayr, Saʿīd ibn al-ʿĀṣ and ʿAbd ar-Raḥmān ibn al-Ḥārith** to copy them into muṣḥafs in the dialect of Quraysh, and sent a copy to each region (al-Bukhārī, 4987).

Every muṣḥaf in the world today follows the writing of the ʿUthmānī muṣḥaf. ʿAlī is reported to have said: “Say nothing but good about ʿUthmān. By Allah, he did what he did with the muṣḥafs only after consulting all of us” (reported by Ibn Abī Dāwūd in al-Maṣāḥif with an authentic chain).

The trial and his martyrdom

In the last years of his caliphate, complaints spread, some of them about governors, and troublemakers stirred them up. In 35 AH, groups of rebels from Egypt, Kūfah and Baṣrah came to Madinah and besieged ʿUthmān in his house for weeks, at times cutting off his water. Many Companions and their sons, among them al-Ḥasan and al-Ḥusayn, ʿAbdullāh ibn az-Zubayr and ʿAbdullāh ibn ʿUmar, wanted to defend him. He ordered them to lay down their weapons and go home, because he did not want blood shed in the city of the Prophet ﷺ on his account.

On 18 Dhul-Ḥijjah 35 AH, the rebels broke in and killed him while he was fasting and reciting the Qur’an, in his eighties. The Prophet ﷺ had foretold it:

> اِفْتَحْ لَهُ وَبَشِّرْهُ بِالْجَنَّةِ عَلَى بَلْوَى تُصِيبُهُ
>
> **“Open for him and give him glad tidings of Paradise, with a trial that will befall him.”**
>
> The Prophet ﷺ about ʿUthmān, narrated by al-Bukhārī (3693) and Muslim (2403). On another occasion, when Mount Uḥud shook beneath the Prophet ﷺ, Abū Bakr, ʿUmar and ʿUthmān, he said: “Be firm, Uḥud, for upon you are a prophet, a ṣiddīq and two martyrs” (al-Bukhārī, 3675).

Lessons for us

1	**Wealth is a means to Paradise** when it is spent for Allah: the well of Rūmah, the army of Tabūk.
2	**Modesty is beautiful**, so much so that the angels felt shy before ʿUthmān.
3	**Unity of the Ummah around the Qur’an** was worth great effort; every muṣḥaf today is a fruit of it.
4	**Patience in trial.** He chose to suffer rather than let Muslims fight in Madinah for his sake.

04

THE FOUR CALIPHS · 04

عَلِيُّ بْنُ أَبِي طَالِبٍ

ABŪ AL-ḤASAN

ʿAlī

ʿAlī ibn Abī Ṭālib al-Hāshimī

Caliph 35 – 40 AH · 656 – 661 CE · Madinah and Kūfah

1st
child to accept Islām

4
years and nine months as caliph

63
years, the length of his life

Caliph 4 ʿAlī ibn Abī Ṭālib: at a glance

Name	ʿAlī ibn Abī Ṭālib ibn ʿAbd al-Muṭṭalib al-Hāshimī al-Qurashī, the Prophet's ﷺ cousin
Kunyah	Abū al-Ḥasan; the Prophet ﷺ also called him **Abū Turāb**, "father of dust"
Born	In Makkah, about ten years before the Prophethood (around 600 CE)
Accepted Islām	As a boy of about ten: the first child to accept Islām
Caliph	From Dhul-Ḥijjah 35 AH to Ramaḍān 40 AH (656–661 CE), about four years and nine months; capital Kūfah from 36 AH
Died	Martyred in Ramaḍān 40 AH (661 CE) in Kūfah, aged about 63
Family	Husband of Fāṭimah, daughter of the Prophet ﷺ; father of al-Ḥasan and al-Ḥusayn

Raised in the house of the Prophet ﷺ

When ʿAlī was a small child, a famine struck Makkah, and the Prophet ﷺ took him into his own home to ease the burden on his uncle Abū Ṭālib. So ʿAlī grew up in the household of the Prophet ﷺ, and when the revelation came he was among the very first to believe, the first of the children.

On the night of the Hijrah, when Quraysh surrounded the Prophet's ﷺ house to kill him, ʿAlī slept in his bed wrapped in his cloak, so that the Prophet ﷺ could leave safely. He stayed behind in Makkah to return the things people had left in the Prophet's ﷺ trust, then followed him to Madinah. In 2 AH he married **Fāṭimah**, the Prophet's ﷺ daughter.

Courage beside the Prophet ﷺ

ʿAlī fought at Badr, Uḥud, the Trench and Khaybar, and was famous for his courage. At Khaybar, after days of siege, the Prophet ﷺ said:

> لَأُعْطِيَنَّ الرَّايَةَ غَدًا رَجُلًا يُحِبُّ اللَّهَ وَرَسُولَهُ، وَيُحِبُّهُ اللَّهُ وَرَسُولُهُ
>
> **"Tomorrow I will give the banner to a man who loves Allah and His Messenger, and whom Allah and His Messenger love."**
>
> Narrated by al-Bukhārī (3701) and Muslim (2406). The next day he gave it to ʿAlī, and Khaybar was opened at his hands.

When the Prophet ﷺ left for Tabūk, he left ʿAlī in charge of his family in Madinah. ʿAlī was sad to stay behind, and the Prophet ﷺ said: "Are you not pleased to be to me as Hārūn was to Mūsā,

except that there is no prophet after me?" (al-Bukhārī 4416, Muslim 2404). He also said: "None loves you but a believer, and none hates you but a hypocrite" (Muslim, 78).

His knowledge

ʿAlī was one of the most knowledgeable Companions, especially in judgement. ʿUmar said: "The best reciter among us is Ubayy, and the best judge among us is ʿAlī" (al-Bukhārī, 4481). The three caliphs before him consulted him constantly, and he advised them sincerely. It was on his advice that ʿUmar dated the calendar from the Hijrah.

> حَدِّثُوا النَّاسَ بِمَا يَعْرِفُونَ، أَتُحِبُّونَ أَنْ يُكَذَّبَ اللَّهُ وَرَسُولُهُ
>
> **"Speak to people according to what they understand. Do you want Allah and His Messenger to be denied?"**
>
> ʿAlī, narrated by al-Bukhārī (127).

Becoming caliph in a time of trial

After the martyrdom of ʿUthmān, the people of Madinah pledged allegiance to ʿAlī. He became caliph in the most difficult circumstances: the rebels were still in the city, and the Ummah was shaken. Many Companions, among them ʿĀʾishah, Ṭalḥah and az-Zubayr, and later Muʿāwiyah and the people of Syria, demanded that ʿUthmān's killers be punished at once. ʿAlī wanted the same justice, but believed the state had to be made secure first, since the killers were many and had tribes behind them.

- **The Battle of the Camel (36 AH)** near Baṣrah: the two sides came close to agreement, but fighting broke out, and the historians report that it was started by those involved in ʿUthmān's killing who feared reconciliation. Ṭalḥah and az-Zubayr were killed. ʿAlī honoured ʿĀʾishah and sent her back to Madinah with respect.
- **Ṣiffīn (37 AH)**: ʿAlī's army met Muʿāwiyah's army from Syria. After heavy losses, both sides agreed to arbitration. During the battle, ʿAmmār ibn Yāsir, who fought with ʿAlī, was killed. The Prophet ﷺ had said of him: "The transgressing group will kill ʿAmmār" (al-Bukhārī 447, Muslim 2916), and the scholars took this as a sign that ʿAlī was in the right.
- **The Khawārij**: a group in ʿAlī's army rejected the arbitration, declared the Muslims disbelievers, and rebelled, saying "Judgement belongs only to Allah." ʿAlī replied: "A word of truth by which falsehood is intended" (Muslim, 1066). He defeated them at an-Nahrawān (38 AH).

How Ahl as-Sunnah understand these events

ʿAlī was the rightful caliph, and he was closer to the truth in these conflicts. Those who opposed him were Companions who acted on their own ijtihād, seeking justice for ʿUthmān. The Prophet ﷺ said that a judge who strives and is right has two rewards, and one who strives and errs has one reward (al-Bukhārī 7352, Muslim 1716).

Allah called both sides believers: "If two groups of the believers fight, make peace between them" (al-Ḥujurāt 49:9). And the Prophet ﷺ said: "Do not revile my Companions" (al-Bukhārī 3673, Muslim 2541). So we love them all, speak well of them all, and do not dig into these events to find fault.

His martyrdom

In Ramaḍān 40 AH, a Khārijī named ʿAbd ar-Raḥmān ibn Muljam struck ʿAlī with a poisoned sword as he went out for the Fajr prayer in Kūfah. He died two days later, aged about 63. It is reported that he told his family not to kill anyone but the attacker, and with a single blow, and not to mutilate him.

His son **al-Ḥasan** was given the pledge, and after about six months he gave up the caliphate to Muʿāwiyah to unite the Muslims, in 41 AH, which became known as the Year of Unity (ʿĀm al-Jamāʿah). The Prophet ﷺ had said of him: "This son of mine is a leader, and perhaps Allah will make peace through him between two great groups of Muslims" (al-Bukhārī, 2704). With this, the thirty years of the rightly guided caliphate were complete.

Lessons for us

1	**Begin young.** ʿAlī accepted Islām as a child and gave his whole life to it.
2	**Sacrifice for the truth.** He slept in the Prophet's ﷺ bed on the night of the Hijrah.
3	**Knowledge and judgement** are among the greatest gifts; ʿUmar called him the best judge.
4	**Justice with mercy**, even towards those who fought him and the man who killed him.
5	**Guard your tongue about the Companions.** Love them all, as Allah and His Messenger ﷺ taught.

Part 6 Brothers in faith: what they said about one another

Some people try to divide the four caliphs, or set the Ahl al-Bayt (the Prophet's ﷺ family) against his Companions. The authentic reports show the opposite: they loved, honoured and trusted one another.

Who	About whom	What he said or did
The Prophet ﷺ	Abū Bakr and ʿUmar	"Follow the two after me: Abū Bakr and ʿUmar" (at-Tirmidhī 3662, ḥasan).
Abū Bakr	The Prophet's ﷺ family	"By the One in whose hand is my soul, the relatives of the Messenger of Allah ﷺ are dearer to me to honour than my own relatives" (al-Bukhārī 3712). And: "Honour Muḥammad ﷺ through his family" (al-Bukhārī 3713).
ʿUmar	ʿAlī	"The best judge among us is ʿAlī" (al-Bukhārī 4481). He consulted ʿAlī in his gravest decisions.
ʿAlī	Abū Bakr and ʿUmar	Named them, in that order, as the best of people after the Prophet ﷺ (al-Bukhārī 3671).
ʿAlī	ʿUmar	Wept over his body and said he had always hoped Allah would place him with his two companions (al-Bukhārī 3685).
ʿAlī	ʿUthmān	"Say nothing but good about ʿUthmān" (Ibn Abī Dāwūd, authentic chain).
ʿAlī's sons	ʿUthmān	al-Ḥasan and al-Ḥusayn stood at ʿUthmān's door to defend him during the siege.

Remember

The Ahl al-Bayt and the Companions were one family in faith. Loving them all, as the Qur'an and Sunnah teach, is the way of Ahl as-Sunnah.

Part 7 The four side by side

	Abū Bakr	ʿUmar	ʿUthmān	ʿAlī
Title	aṣ-Ṣiddīq	al-Fārūq	Dhun-Nūrayn	Abū Turāb
Clan of Quraysh	Taym	ʿAdī	Umayyah	Hāshim
Accepted Islām	First free man	About 6th year	Early, via Abū Bakr	First child
Tie to the Prophet ﷺ	Father-in-law	Father-in-law	Son-in-law twice	Cousin and son-in-law
How chosen	Pledge at as-Saqīfah, then general pledge	Named by Abū Bakr after consultation	Shūrā of six	Pledge in Madinah
Caliphate	11–13 AH	13–23 AH	23–35 AH	35–40 AH
Best-known work	Riddah wars; Qur'an gathered	Conquests; calendar; dīwān	Standard muṣḥaf; navy	Justice; facing the Khawārij
Death	Illness	Martyred at Fajr	Martyred in his house	Martyred at Fajr
Age	63	63	In his eighties	About 63
Buried	Beside the Prophet ﷺ	Beside the Prophet ﷺ	al-Baqīʿ	Kūfah

Timeline of key events

Year	Event
11 AH (632 CE)	The Prophet ﷺ dies. Abū Bakr becomes caliph. The army of Usāmah sets out. The riddah wars begin.
12 AH (633)	Battle of al-Yamāmah. The Qur'an is gathered under Zayd ibn Thābit.
13 AH (634)	Battle of Ajnādayn. Abū Bakr dies; ʿUmar becomes caliph.
15 AH (636)	Battle of al-Yarmūk.
15–16 AH (636–637)	Battle of al-Qādisiyyah; al-Madāʾin opened.
16 AH (637)	ʿUmar receives Jerusalem.
c. 17 AH (638)	The Hijrī calendar adopted.
18 AH (639)	The Year of Ashes (famine) and the plague of ʿAmwās.
20–21 AH (641–642)	Egypt opened. Battle of Nahāwand.
23 AH (644)	ʿUmar martyred. The shūrā chooses ʿUthmān.
c. 25 AH	ʿUthmān sends the standard muṣḥaf to the regions.
c. 28 AH (649)	First naval expedition, to Cyprus.
35 AH (656)	ʿUthmān martyred. ʿAlī becomes caliph.
36 AH (656)	Battle of the Camel. ʿAlī moves to Kūfah.
37 AH (657)	Ṣiffīn and the arbitration.
38 AH (658)	ʿAlī defeats the Khawārij at an-Nahrawān.
40 AH (661)	ʿAlī martyred in Kūfah.
41 AH (661)	Al-Ḥasan makes peace: the Year of Unity. Thirty years are complete.

Part 8 Lessons for today

What the rightly guided caliphs teach us

1	**Leadership is a trust, not a prize.** Each of them feared the responsibility and served the people.
2	**Consultation (shūrā)** guided their choices, from choosing a caliph to dating the calendar.
3	**The Qur'an and the Sunnah came first.** Abū Bakr gathered the Qur'an, ʿUthmān united the Ummah on one muṣḥaf, and all four held to the Sunnah.
4	**Simple living**: rulers of empires who ate plain food and wore patched clothes.
5	**Justice for all**, including those of other faiths in Jerusalem and beyond.
6	**Unity and love among believers**, and silence about the faults of the Companions.

Test Self-test

Choose the best answer. The answers are on the next page.

1. Who was the first free man to accept Islām?

a) ʿUmar b) Abū Bakr c) ʿUthmān d) ʿAlī

2. Why was Abū Bakr called aṣ-Ṣiddīq?

a) For his wealth b) For affirming the Prophet ﷺ, as after the Night Journey c) For his poetry d) For his courage at Badr

3. Which verse did Abū Bakr recite on the day the Prophet ﷺ died?

a) Āl ʿImrān 3:144 b) al-Fātiḥah c) Āyat al-Kursī d) al-Ikhlāṣ

4. Who gathered the Qur'an into one book under Abū Bakr?

a) ʿAbdullāh ibn Masʿūd b) Ubayy ibn Kaʿb c) Zayd ibn Thābit d) Muʿādh ibn Jabal

5. What does "al-Fārūq" mean?

a) The generous b) The one who separates truth from falsehood c) The first d) The judge

6. Which companion said "We have been strong ever since ʿUmar accepted Islām"?

a) ʿAbdullāh ibn Masʿūd b) Bilāl c) Abū Hurayrah d) Salmān

7. The Hijrī calendar was adopted under:

a) Abū Bakr b) ʿUmar c) ʿUthmān d) ʿAlī

8. Which city did ʿUmar travel to receive in person?

a) Damascus b) Jerusalem c) Cairo d) Kūfah

9. Why was ʿUthmān called Dhun-Nūrayn?

a) He married two daughters of the Prophet ﷺ b) He had two lamps c) He prayed at night d) He memorised two books

10. Who urged ʿUthmān to unite the Muslims on one muṣḥaf?

a) Ḥudhayfah ibn al-Yamān b) Khālid ibn al-Walīd c) Abū Mūsā d) Saʿd ibn Abī Waqqāṣ

11. Which caliph bought the well of Rūmah for the Muslims?

a) Abū Bakr b) ʿUmar c) ʿUthmān d) ʿAlī

12. Who slept in the Prophet's ﷺ bed on the night of the Hijrah?

a) Abū Bakr b) ʿAlī c) Zayd ibn Ḥārithah d) ʿUmar

13. ʿUmar said "the best judge among us is":

a) ʿAlī b) Ubayy c) Muʿādh d) Zayd

14. How do Ahl as-Sunnah regard the Companions who fought in the fitnah?

a) With love, holding that they acted on ijtihād b) As enemies c) As disbelievers d) As people to be cursed

15. How long did the Prophet ﷺ say the caliphate would last?

a) Ten years b) Twenty years c) Thirty years d) One hundred years

Answers Answers and reflection

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	b) Abū Bakr	9	a) He married two daughters of the Prophet ﷺ
2	b) For affirming the Prophet ﷺ	10	a) Ḥudhayfah ibn al-Yamān
3	a) Āl ʿImrān 3:144	11	c) ʿUthmān
4	c) Zayd ibn Thābit	12	b) ʿAlī
5	b) The one who separates truth from falsehood	13	a) ʿAlī
6	a) ʿAbdullāh ibn Masʿūd	14	a) With love, holding that they acted on ijtihād
7	b) ʿUmar	15	c) Thirty years
8	b) Jerusalem		

Activities

1 Which caliph's story moved you most, and why?

.....

.....

.....

2 Choose one quality from each caliph that you want in your own life. How will you practise it this month?

.....

.....

.....

3 Learn one ḥadīth about each caliph by heart this week, with its source.

.....

.....

.....

Glossary Words to know

Term	Meaning
Khalīfah	Successor: the one who led the Muslims after the Prophet ﷺ.
Ar-Rāshidūn	The rightly guided.
Bayʿah	The pledge of allegiance given to a leader.
Shūrā	Consultation among the people of knowledge and standing.
As-Saqīfah	The hall of Banū Sāʿidah in Madinah, where Abū Bakr was first given the pledge.
Ar-Riddah	Apostasy; the wars against the tribes that left Islām or refused zakāh after the Prophet's ﷺ death.
Dīwān	The government register of soldiers and stipends, begun by ʿUmar.
Muṣḥaf	A written copy of the Qur'an.
Fitnah	Trial or turmoil; used for the conflicts of the later years.
Ijtihād	A qualified person's sincere effort to reach the right judgement.
Khawārij	The group that rebelled against ʿAlī and declared other Muslims disbelievers.
Ahl al-Bayt	The family of the Prophet ﷺ.
Al-ʿAsharah al-Mubashsharūn	The ten Companions named together as people of Paradise.

For further reading

- **Tārīkh al-Khulafā'**, as-Suyūṭī, on the caliphs (available in English as "The History of the Khalifahs who took the right way").
- **al-Bidāyah wan-Nihāyah**, Ibn Kathīr, volumes on the caliphate.
- **aṭ-Ṭabaqāt al-Kubrā**, Ibn Saʿd, biographies of the Companions.
- **al-ʿAwāṣim min al-Qawāṣim**, Abū Bakr ibn al-ʿArabī, on understanding the fitnah correctly.
- The biographies of each caliph by **ʿAlī Muḥammad aṣ-Ṣallābī** (Arabic, with English translations).

Du‘ā’ For those who came before us

رَبَّنَا اغْفِرْ لَنَا وَلِإِخْوَانِنَا الَّذِينَ سَبَقُونَا بِالْإِيمَانِ وَلَا تَجْعَلْ فِي قُلُوبِنَا غِلًّا لِّلَّذِينَ آمَنُوا رَبَّنَا إِنَّكَ رَءُوفٌ رَّحِيمٌ

“Our Lord, forgive us and our brothers who preceded us in faith, and put not in our hearts any resentment toward those who have believed. Our Lord, You are Kind and Merciful.”

Al-Ḥashr 59:10.

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